The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: EPA

Ukraine and **Russia** ended their second day of American-led peace negotiations in Geneva after just two hours. The talks have been "very tense", said a source quoted by Russian media; Volodymyr Zelensky called them "difficult". Ukraine's president accused Russia of dragging out negotiations instead of moving towards an agreement to end the four-year war.

Mark Zuckerberg, Meta's boss, is due to testify in a trial about Instagram's effect on the mental health of its young users. The case is the first of more than 1,600 lawsuits, which allege that social-media platforms were designed to be addictive. Meta denies wrongdoing. A ruling against it could mean that tech firms lose the legal protections that have shielded them from being sued.

Donald Trump said **Japan** would invest $36bn in **America** in the first phase of the countries' "massive trade deal", which was agreed last year. The money will go to three energy and manufacturing projects, including a natural-gas plant in Ohio. Japan has pledged to invest $550bn in America in exchange for the Trump administration limiting tariffs on Japanese exports to 15%.

Uber said it will spend over $100m on charging hubs to support its expansion into the robotaxi industry. The firm will install fast

chargers at its operating bases and in busy parts of major cities, starting in San Francisco, Los Angeles and Dallas. The move comes as competition in robotaxi services from Tesla and Alphabet's Waymo intensifies.

French prosecutors started two inquiries into alleged human and financial crimes linked to **Jeffrey Epstein**, a dead sex offender, following the release of fresh documents. Five magistrates will examine the Epstein files to assess whether any French nationals are implicated. Authorities said they hoped that renewed scrutiny will prompt victims to come forward. An earlier French probe was closed in 2023.

Britain's annual **inflation** rate fell to 3% in January, down from 3.4% in December and the lowest in nearly a year. The drop was driven by a decrease in fuel prices. The new data increases the chance that the Bank of England will cut interest rates when it meets next month.

Gabon blocked several social-media platforms, claiming that online content threatened public order. It did not name the services, though internet monitors reported disruptions to Meta, YouTube and TikTok. Civil-society representatives warned that the suspension would affect businesses and restrict free speech. In 2023 Brice Oligui Nguema led a coup that ended more than five decades of Bongo family rule, and has since consolidated his power.

Figure of the day: 5.6trn roubles ($73bn), Russia's budget deficit in 2025, the largest since the pandemic. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

France’s economy resists, just

On Wednesday Insee, France’s official statistics agency, revealed that in January the annual inflation rate fell to just 0.3%, a five-year low. France’s economic growth remains weaker than the euro-zone average: its GDP is expected to expand by 1% in 2026, compared with 1.2% for the zone as a whole. But this is the same rate as in Germany, its biggest trading partner. It is also better than many analysts had expected given the political deadlock that created so much uncertainty in France last year.

Aeronautical and defence exports are bolstering growth. Dassault, a manufacturer of fighter jets, is hoping to finalise a mega deal with India for 114 new aircraft. But the poor state of France’s public finances, and the government’s decision to extend a super tax on businesses for another year, will continue to weigh on the economy. With the next presidential election in 2027, much political uncertainty remains.

Photograph: Reuters

Denmark’s king heads to the Arctic

King Frederik X of Denmark begins a three-day visit to Greenland on Wednesday. Donald Trump’s insistence that America should control the self-governing island, which is part of the kingdom of Denmark, has shaken the transatlantic alliance. Last month America’s president abandoned his threat of tariffs and ruled out using force. But on February 14th Mette Frederiksen, Denmark’s prime minister, warned that his demands remain “exactly the same”.

King Frederik hopes his trip will lift Greenlanders’ “morale”. Despite the island’s strong independence movement, the king is popular there. In 2000 he joined an expedition across Greenland with the Sirius Dog Sled Patrol, a Danish military unit. Two of his children have Greenlandic middle names. A deal is reportedly in the works to give America’s armed forces greater access to Greenland, though Denmark and Greenland insist that their “territorial integrity” is a “red line”. For Danes and Greenlanders, the king’s visit will underscore that the island’s future is not America’s to decide.

Photograph: Getty Images

Takaichi Sanae becomes Japan’s prime minister, again

On Wednesday Takaichi Sanae was sworn in for the second time in six months. She has held the post since October 2025, after her predecessor resigned. Now, though, she has a proper public mandate—having won a snap election on February 8th by a landslide. Ms Takaichi faces the daunting task of passing the budget for the next fiscal year, which begins in April. That deadline is tight, particularly given the amount of time lost to campaigning in recent months.

Elsewhere, though, her position is strong. Ms Takaichi called the election because she wanted the ability to pursue “bold policies” that might otherwise have met with too much resistance. She has it: the ruling Liberal Democratic Party now holds a two-thirds supermajority in the lower house, enough to overrule the upper chamber. Ms Takaichi wants to strengthen Japan’s armed forces, which will include creating a foreign intelligence agency and an anti-espionage law. Such proposals would normally be strongly opposed in pacifist Japan.

Photograph: Getty Images

Britain’s largest defence firm is flying high

On Wednesday BAE Systems, one of the world’s biggest defence firms, posted its full-year results for 2025. It was a good year for the company: sales rose by 10% to £30.7bn; the already-bulging order backlog has grown to £83.6bn. Such success should not come as a surprise. Fractious geopolitics—and indications by the British government that it intends to ramp up defence spending—has meant strong demand. BAE recently landed two big new contracts. One is to build anti-submarine warships for Norway. The other is to supply 20 top-of-the-range fighter jets to Turkey. The firm is already working on the next generation of fighter jets too, in collaboration with Italy’s Leonardo and Japan’s Mitsubishi.

BAE‘s prospects might be looking better still if it weren’t for Brexit. Britain’s departure from the EU means the company has less access to the continent’s own booming defence market. Fearful of Russian aggression and possible abandonment by America, European countries are massively increasing their military spending.

Photograph: Getty Images

Bernie battles California's billionaires

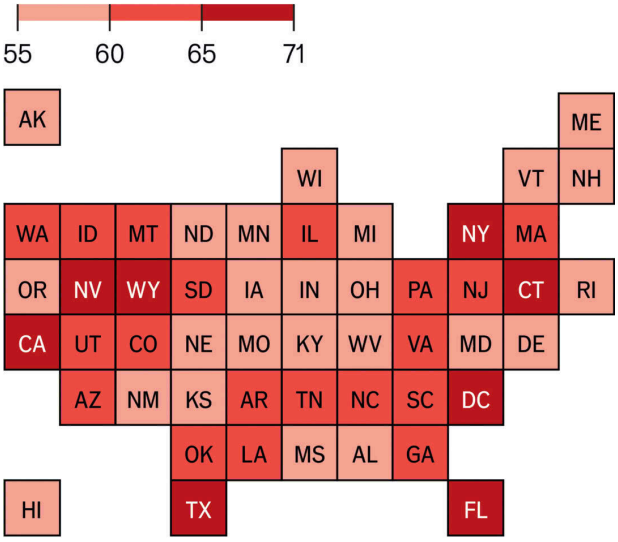
"Billionaire" is a dirty word at Bernie Sanders' rallies. During one in Los Angeles on Wednesday the 84-year-old senator for Vermont will use the term to rouse support for a 5% wealth tax on Californians whose net worth is over $1.1bn. That would prop up the state's struggling health-care system, argues the SEIU, a trade union sponsoring the proposal. It will need to secure nearly 900,000 signatures before June 24th to get on California's November ballot.

Democrats have embraced the issue of "affordability" ahead of the midterm elections. But they disagree over how to actually help Americans. Mr Sanders—an independent who caucuses with Democrats—argues that America is ravaged by wealth inequality and run by oligarchs. Moderates worry that wealth taxes in blue cities and states will drive the rich to Republican states, raising little extra money. For better or worse, California may be the testing ground.

Haves and have-lots

Income inequality*, Gini coefficient, 2022

100=maximum inequality



*Before taxes and transfers

Source: US state-level income inequality, M. Frank, August 2025

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Which famous drummer was one of the founder members of the rock group Cream?

Tuesday: Grey, blood and basset are words that precede the name of what type of dog?

A person needs a little madness, or else they never dare cut the rope and be free.

Nikos Kazantzakis